

Lecture 2.

Sorting algorithms.

Algorithms and Data Structures
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Barcelona, 03 February 2026

Outline

- Sorting problem statement
- Quadratic $O(N^2)$ sorting algorithms
 - Selection sort
 - Insertion sort
 - Bubble sort
- Linearithmic $O(N \log N)$ sorting algorithms
 - Merge sort
 - Quick sort
 - Heap sort (later)
- Greedy algorithms

Problem statement

Given sequence of objects (let's suppose they're integer numbers for simplicity).

$$x_0, x_1, \dots, x_{N-1}: x_i \in X \quad (1)$$

Also given binary relation $\leq$ (transitive, reflexive) on X .

Task is to reorder elements:

$$x_{i_0}, x_{i_1}, \dots, x_{i_{N-1}} \quad (2)$$

$$x_{i_0} \leq x_{i_1} \leq \dots \leq x_{i_{N-1}} \quad (3)$$

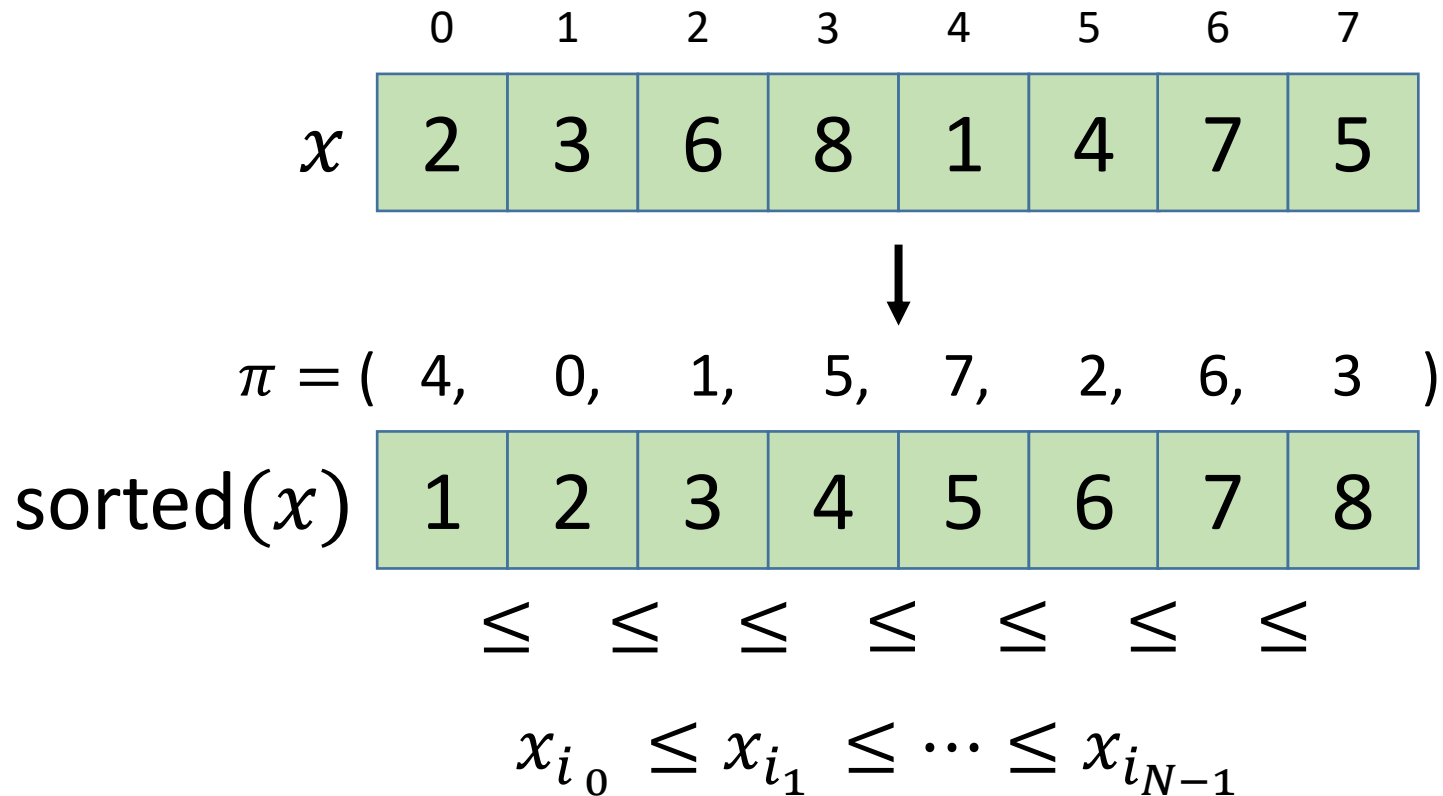
Sequence of source indices used to reorder elements construct a permutation:

$$\pi = (i_0, i_1, \dots, i_{N-1})$$

In other words, the task is to find a permutation that will satisfy (3).

Problem statement

Example



Problem statement

Example

0	1	2	3	4	5	6	7
2	3	6	8	1	4	7	5



(2, 0)	(3, 1)	(6, 2)	(8, 3)	(1, 4)	(4, 5)	(7, 6)	(5, 7)
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(1, 4)	(2, 0)	(3, 1)	(4, 5)	(5, 7)	(6, 2)	(7, 6)	(8, 3)
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$$\pi = (4, 0, 1, 5, 7, 2, 6, 3)$$

Quadratic $O(N^2)$ sorting algorithms

- **Selection sort**
- Insertion sort
- Bubble sort

Selection sort

Idea

Let's sort array in range $[i, N)$ (initially: $i = 0$):

1. Let's find minimum value in range $[i, N)$: $x_{i_{min}}$.
2. We know the place $x_{i_{min}}$ should take in sorted array: i -th.
3. Let's swap $x_{i_{min}}$ with value on it's desired place.
4. Now, let's sort the rest array ($x[i + 1:]$) using the same approach ($i += 1$ and go to 1.).

	0	1	2	3	4	5	6	7
x	4	2	5	6	3	1	7	8

Selection sort

Implementation

```
N = len(x)
for i in range(N - 1):
    i_min = i
    for j in range(i + 1, N):
        if x[j] < x[i_min]:
            i_min = j
    x[i], x[i_min] = x[i_min], x[i]
```

Complexity: $N - 1 + N - 2 + \dots + 1 = N(N - 1)/2 = O(N^2)$

Quadratic $O(N^2)$ sorting algorithms

- Selection sort
- **Insertion sort**
- Bubble sort

Insertion sort

Idea

This sorting algorithm works similar to the way you sort playing cards in your hands:

You have a sorted part of array in the left, and for each new element you look for a place in sorted part to insert this element, and then insert it, shifting elements to the right if needed.

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1	2	3	4	5	6	7	8

Insertion sort

Implementation

```
N = len(x)
for i in range(1, N):
    key = x[i]
    j = i - 1
    while j >= 0 and key < x[j]:
        x[j + 1] = x[j]
        j -= 1
    x[j + 1] = key
```

Quadratic $O(N^2)$ sorting algorithms

- Selection sort
- Insertion sort
- **Bubble sort**

Bubble sort

Idea

Let's sort array in range $[0, N - i)$ (initially: $i = 0$):

1. Let's iterate over $j \in [0, N - i)$ and for each j , check if it's more than next value ($j + 1$), swap j and $j + 1$ elements.
2. After loop 1., maximum element will go right (float like a bubble).
3. Let's increase i and sort the rest of the array: $x[:N-i]$.

0	1	2	3	4	5
4	2	5	6	3	1

Bubble sort

Idea

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0	1	2	3	4	5
2	1	3	4	5	6

Bubble sort

Implementation

```
N = len(x)
for i in range(0, N - 1):
    for j in range(0, N - i - 1):
        if x[j] > x[j + 1]:
            x[j], x[j + 1] = x[j + 1], x[j]
```

Complexity:

$$1 + 2 + \dots + N - 1 = N(N - 1)/2 = O(N^2)$$

Linearithmic sorting algorithms
 $O(N \log N)$

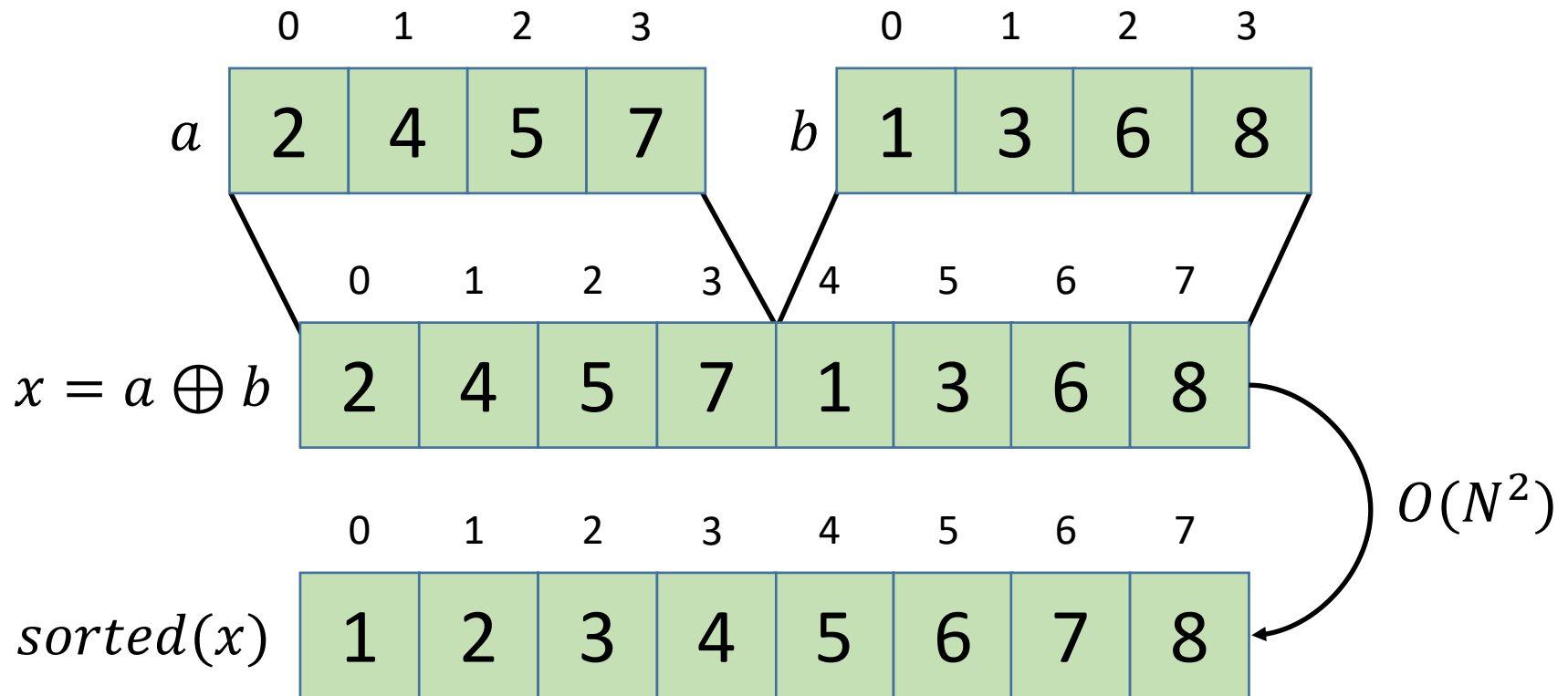
- **Merge sort**
- Quick sort

Divide and conquer paradigm

Merge sort

Merging

Let's suppose, we need to sort array which is a union of two sorted arrays, $\frac{N}{2}$ each. How fast can we sort it?

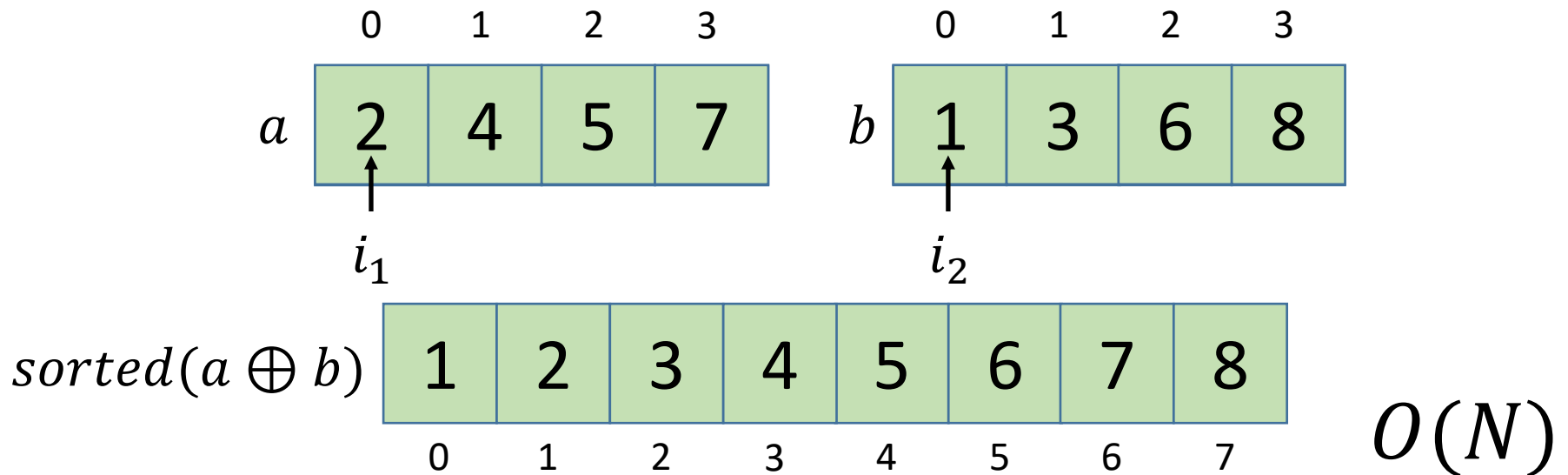


Merge sort

Merging

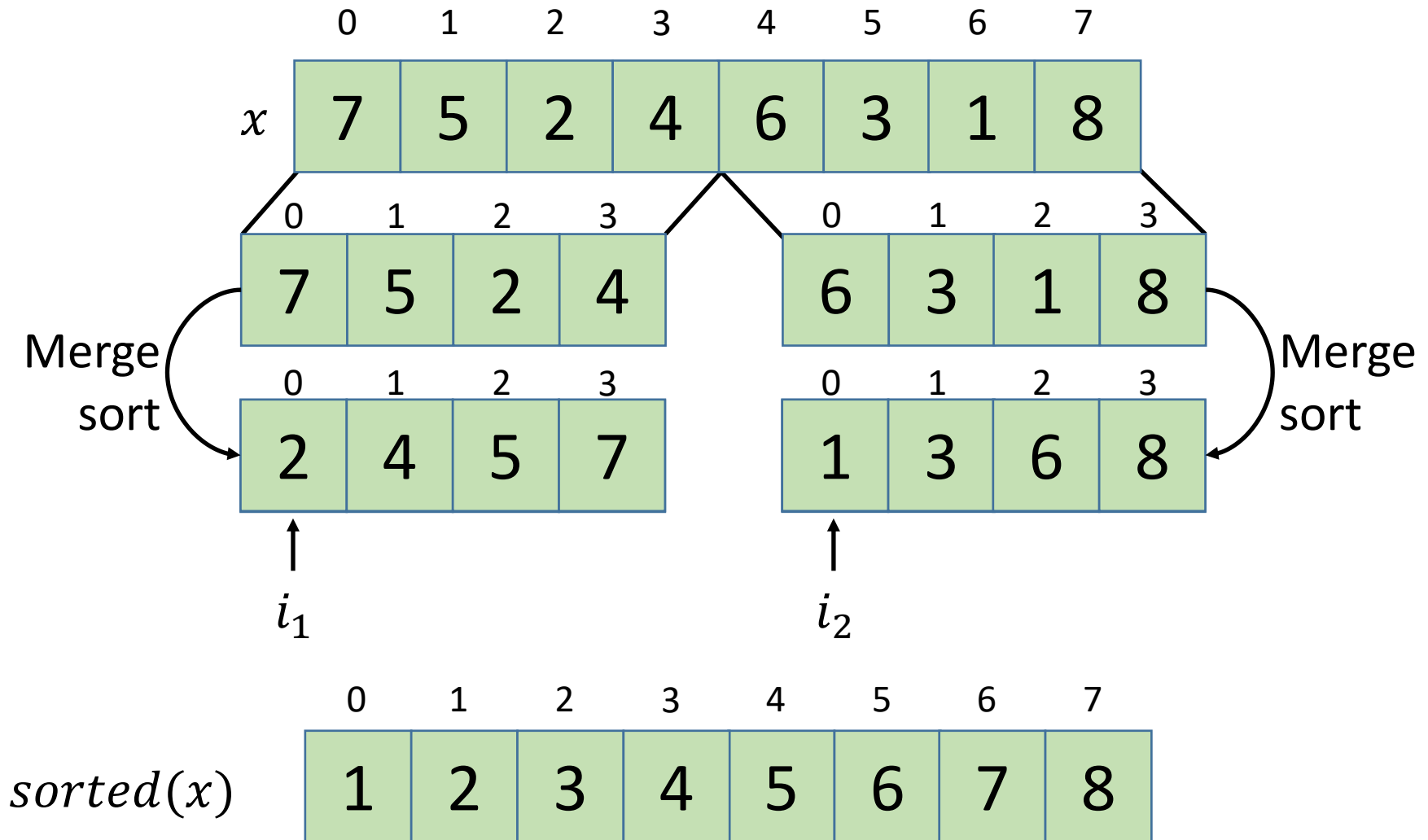
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We create two indices i_1 , i_2 and add minimum of $a[i_1]$, $b[i_2]$ to result array, step-by-step, increasing corresponding index.



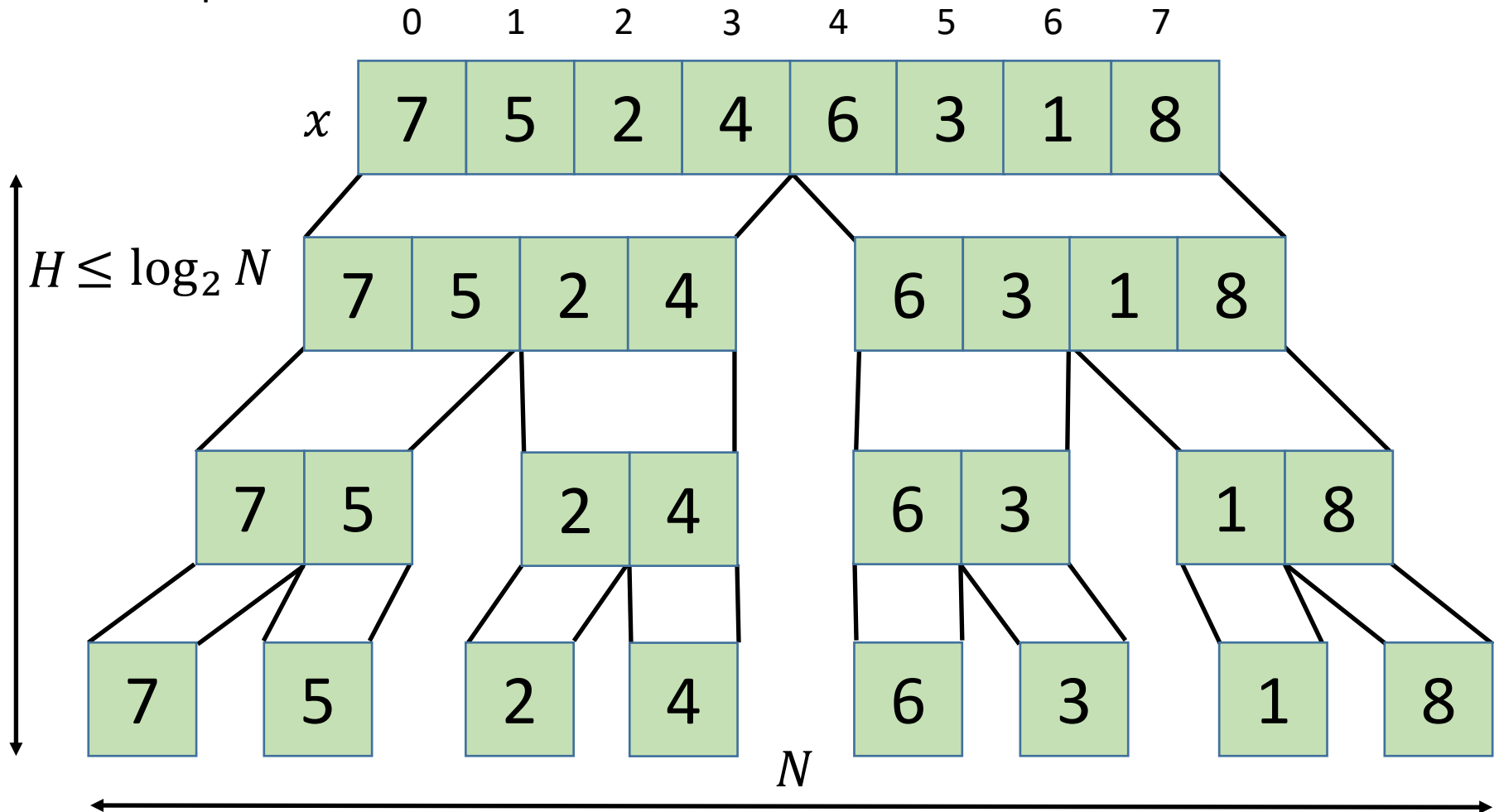
Merge sort

Divide



Merge sort

Conquer



Complexity: $O(N \log N)$

Merge sort

Implementation

```
def merge(x, l, m, r):  
    tmp = []  
    i1 = l  
    i2 = m  
    while i1 < m or i2 < r:  
        if (i2 >= r) or ((i1 < m) and  
                        (x[i1] < x[i2])):  
            tmp.append(x[i1])  
            i1 += 1  
        else:  
            tmp.append(x[i2])  
            i2 += 1  
    x[l:r] = tmp
```

Merge sort

Implementation

```
def merge_sort(x, l=0, r=None):  
    if r is None:  
        r = len(x)  
    if r - l > 1:  
        m = (l + r) // 2  
        merge_sort(x, l, m)  
        merge_sort(x, m, r)
```

Linearithmic sorting algorithms
 $O(N \log N)$

- Merge sort
- **Quick sort**

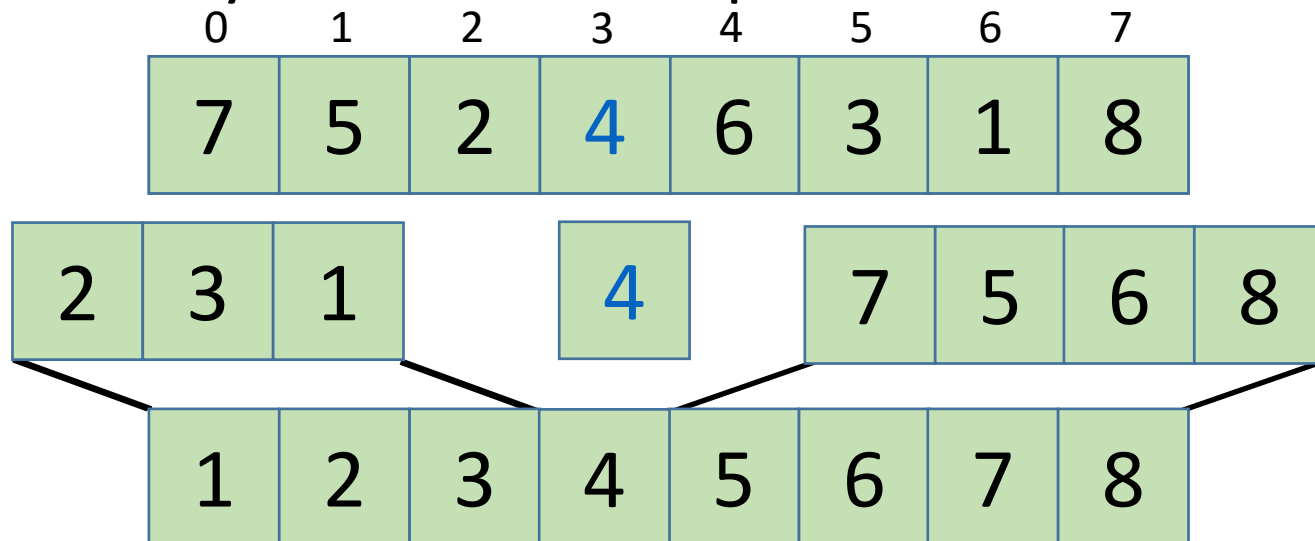
Divide and conquer paradigm

QSort

Idea

QSort also uses Divide and Conquer approach, but dividing method is different.

1. Select pivot element (any element from array)
2. Divide by 3 parts: elements $<$ pivot, $=$ pivot, $>$ pivot
3. Recursively sort 1st and 3rd parts.



QSort

Partition

Let's denote division into 3 parts with indices i_l, i_r .

Array to be partitioned is in range $[l, r)$.

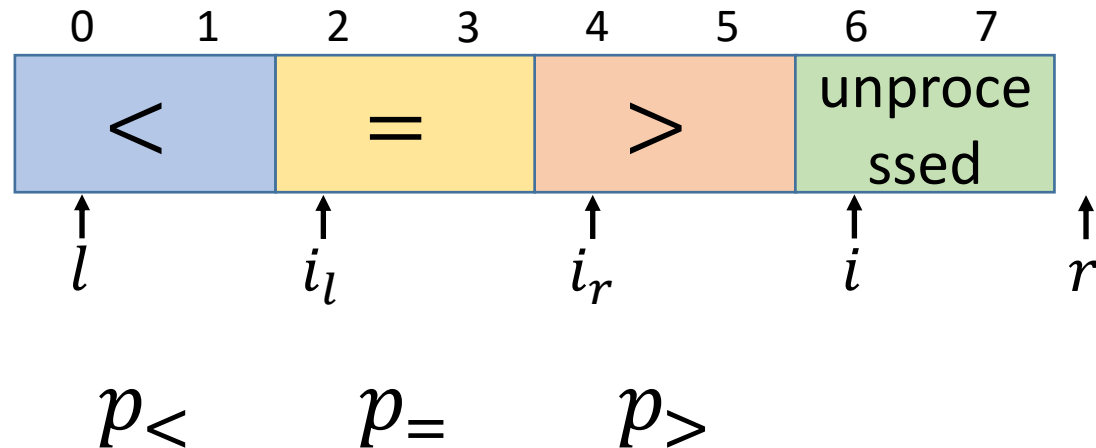
Division is correct in range $[0, i)$.

$x < pivot: [l, i_l)$

$x == pivot: [i_l, i_r)$

$x > pivot: [i_r, i)$

Unprocessed: $[i, r)$

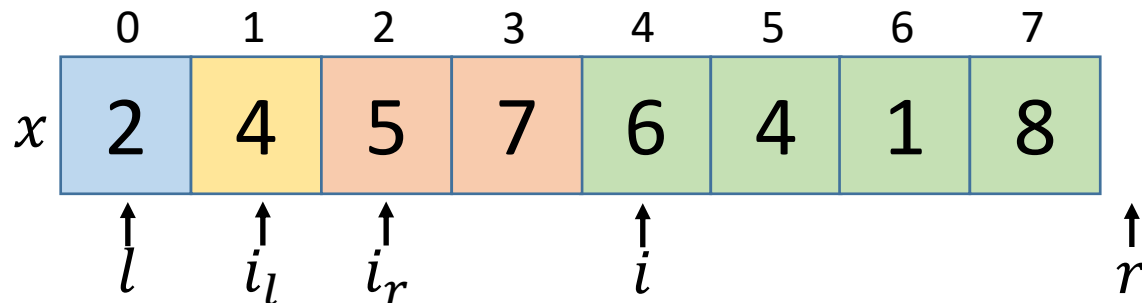


QSort

Partition

Adding element to $p_{>}$.

1. Element already stands on it's place.

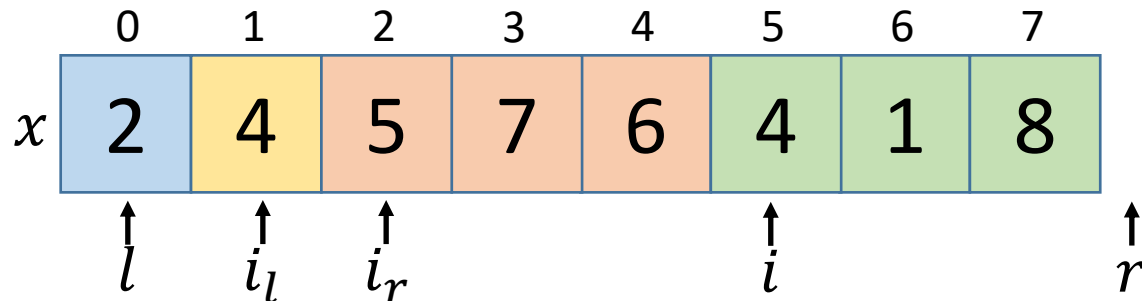


QSort

Partition

Adding element to $p_{=}$.

1. Swap $x[i_r]$ and $x[i]$.
2. Increase i_r .

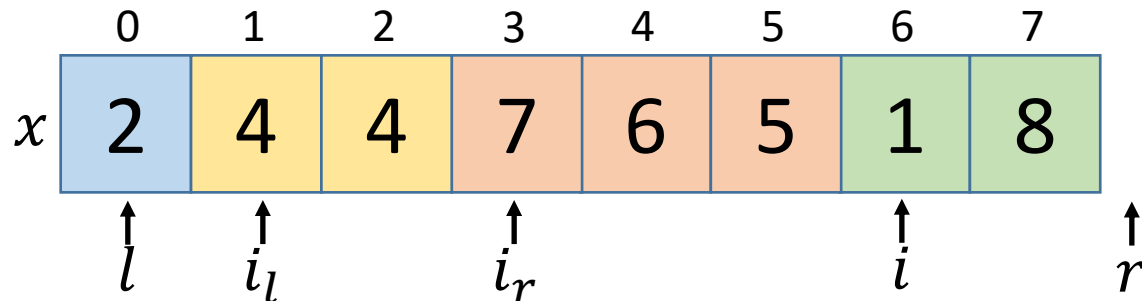


QSort

Partition

Adding element to $p_{<}$.

1. Swap $x[i_l]$ and $x[i]$.
2. If 2-nd part was not empty ($i_l < i_r$), $x[i]$ is from $p_{=}$ and we need to return it (as on previous slide).
Otherwise, $x[i]$ is from $p_{>}$, and it stands on it's place
3. Increase i_l and i_r .



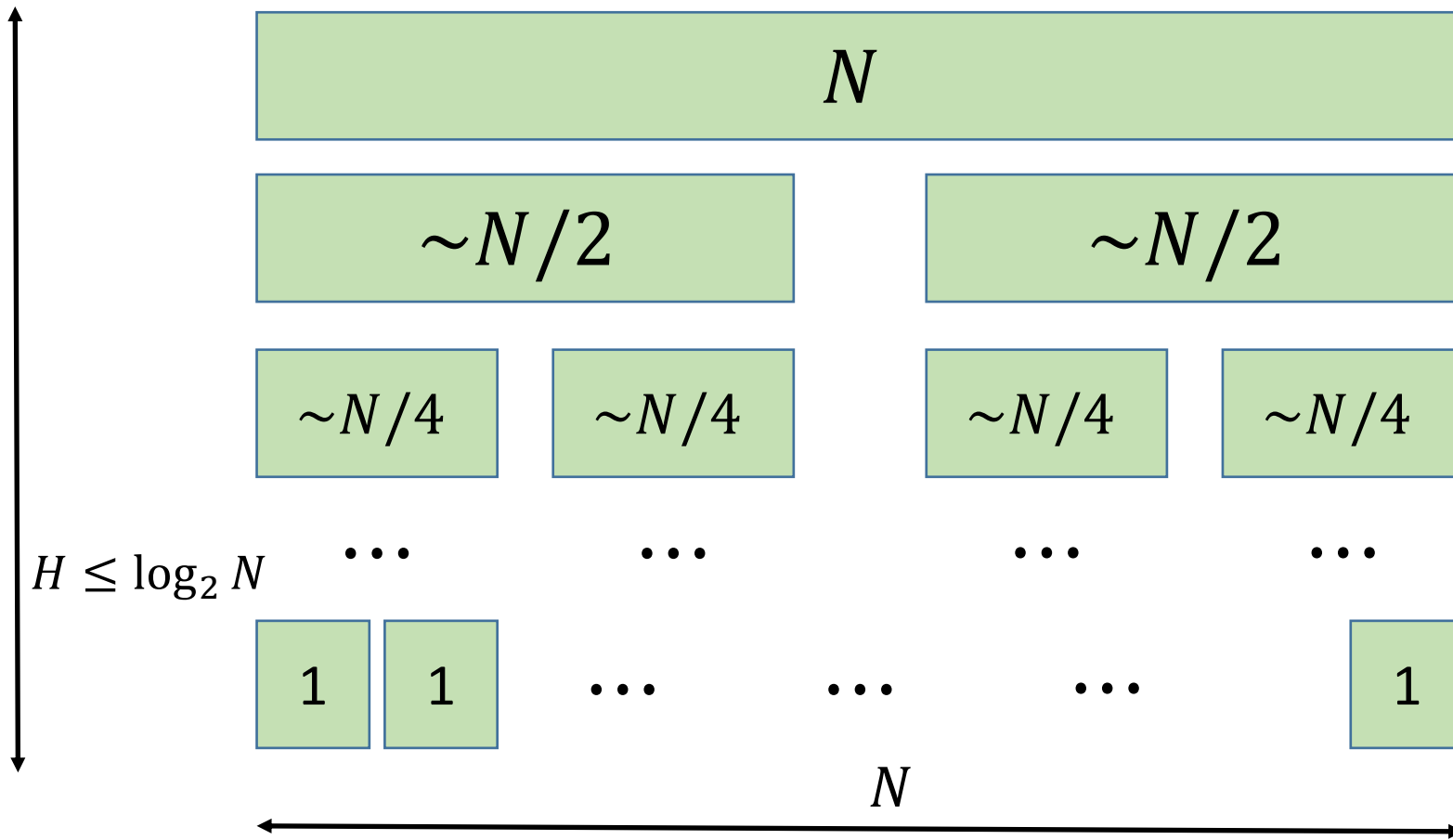
QSort

Implementation

```
def qsort(x, l=0, r=None):  
    if r is None:  
        r = len(x)  
    if (r - l) > 1:  
        pivot = x[(l + r) // 2]  
        il, ir = partition(x, l, r, pivot)  
        qsort(x, l, il)  
        qsort(x, ir, r)
```

QSort

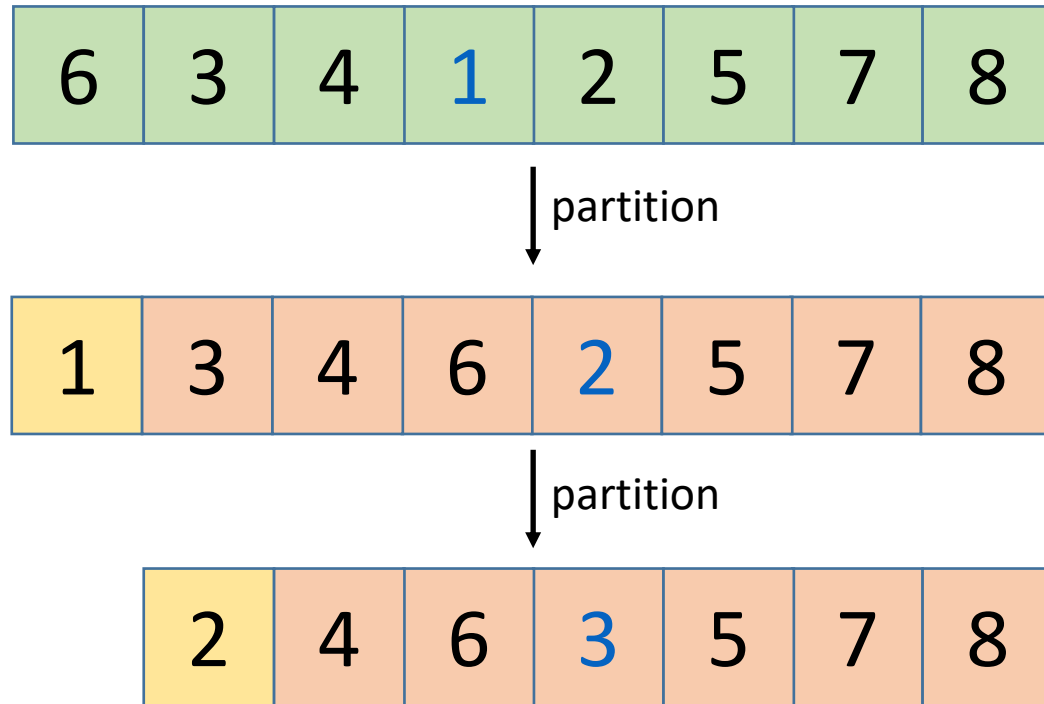
Complexity



Complexity: $O(N \log N)$

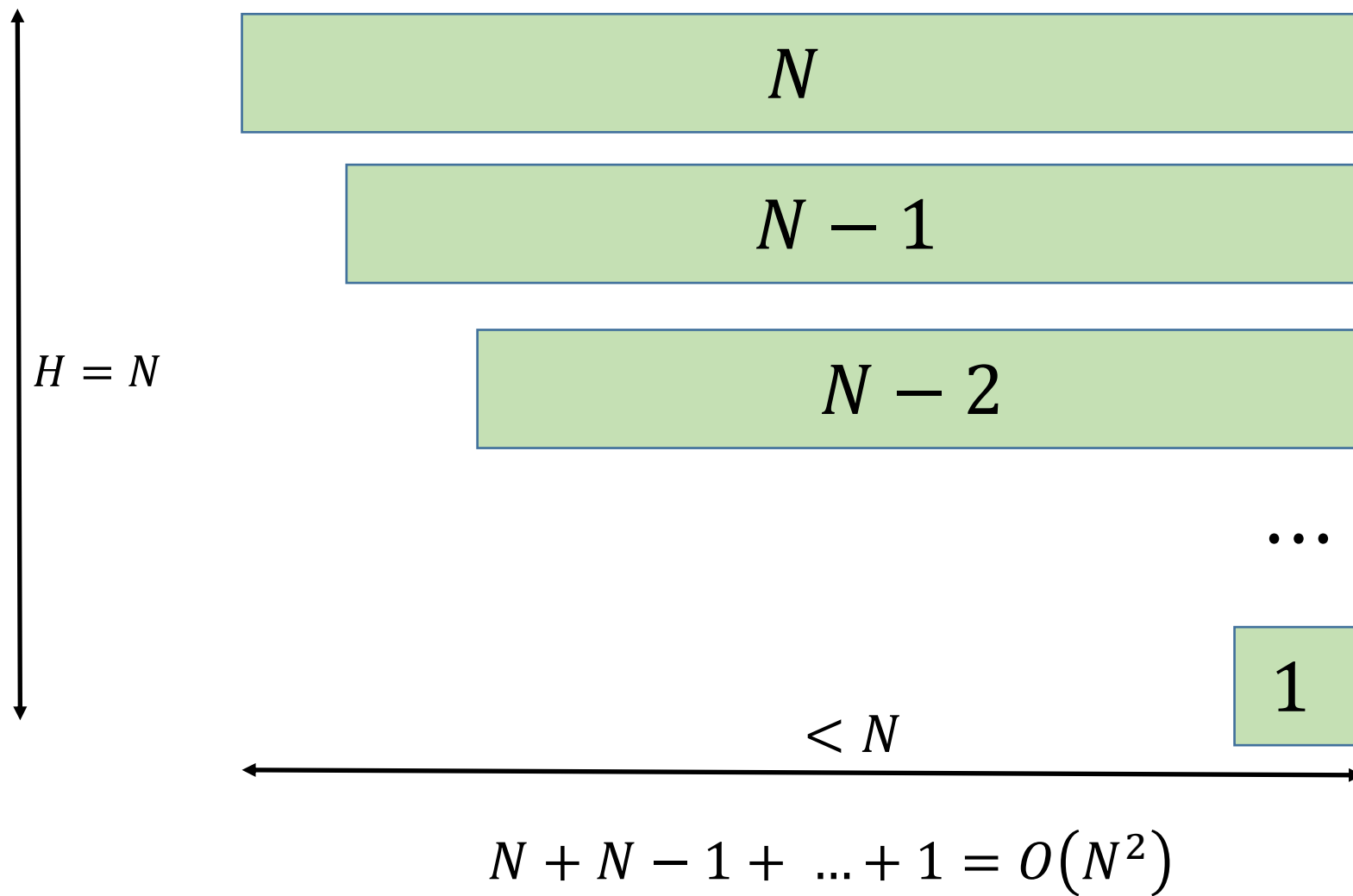
QSort

Complexity



QSort

Complexity



QSort

Implementation

```
import random
def qsort(x, l=0, r=None):
    if r is None:
        r = len(x)
    if (r - l) > 1:
        pivot = x[random.randint(l, r - 1)]
        il, ir = partition(x, l, r, pivot)
        qsort(x, l, il)
        qsort(x, ir, r)
```

Greedy algorithm

Definition

Greedy algorithm builds up a solution piece by piece, always choosing the next piece that offers the most obvious and immediate benefit.

So on each step it chooses locally optimal solution.

Greedy algorithm

Example

Problem: Ali Baba 1

Ali-baba entered the cave with lot's of treasures. He can hold only N items in his hands. You are given list of all items in the cave with their costs. Help Ali Baba take out items with maximum total cost.

Solution:

Let's sort elements in non-increasing cost order and take top N elements.

Proof (informal):

Let's suppose, our solution A is not optimal. That means that exists a better solution B . A and B differs at least by 1 item, but if we replace any item in A with another, total sum will not increase, because our solution contains top-cost items. Contradiction.

Conclusion

$$O(N^2): N \leq 1000$$

$$O(N \log N): N \leq 100000$$

Python built-ins

```
import random  
x = [random.randint(0, 100000) for i in range(100000)]  
y = sorted(x)  
x.sort()
```

Visualizers

- <https://sortvisualizer.com/mergesort/>
- www.youtube.com/user/AlgoRythmics

Thank you for watching!